and again were marked by the use of forced labour,[118] beatings, rape and land theft.[119] The latter involved the construction of villages in northern Rakhine for non-Rohingyas built on land taken from older Rohingya settlements[120] and often built with forced Rohingya labour. The villages were then populated by Burmese who were brought into the region and given substantial agriculture production targets by the military. There are reported instances of Rohingyas leasing back the land from the new owners in order that the production targets be met.

Not only were the Rohingyas displaced from their villages by the new villages or army bases,[121] but those forced to return from Bangladesh found their previous communities had been destroyed and re-appropriated by groups favoured by the state. Typically, this led to renewed tensions, and subsequently more repression and a continuation of the refugee flow[122] to both Bangladesh and Malaysia.

Bangladesh consistently and forcibly sent back refugees to Burma,[123] including those who had fled in the 1970s and again in the early 1990s, in violation of various UN declarations on universal human rights and the rights of refugees.[124] Those who fled to Malaysia have often been allowed to stay, but as stateless refugees, since the Burmese government will not accept them back[125] and the Malay officials are prepared neither to force their removal nor to provide them with proper refugee status.

A target of choice

There is a clear racial aspect to the overall pattern of legal discrimination against the Rohingyas.[126] However, it must be stressed that the persecution and discrimination against the Rohingyas was not a particular feature of Burma at independence. Instead, they were subject to the official distrust of all non-Burman groups and the situation has been quite deliberately worsened since then. There is ample evidence from the 1950s and 1960s that the Rohingyas were just one of many ethnic groups in the country who faced discrimination, but were also an accepted part of the ethnic patchwork.

One important reason for the change to more direct persecution in the 1970s was that the Burmese Road to Socialism was proving to be an economic disaster. The regime needed an easily identifiable group it could